

THE FACE OF CHANGE Lalduhoma poses with ZPM members after the win, Dec. 4

ASSEMBLY POLLS 2023

MIZORAM

A NEW FORCE IN AIZAWL

THE ZPM BREAKS THE MNF-CONGRESS STRANGLEHOLD TO SEIZE POWER IN MIZORAM. FRESH FACES AND PROMISE OF CHANGE DID THE TRICK

By **KAUSHIK DEKA**

On December 4, the declaration of results of the assembly election in Mizoram heralded a new era of power politics in the northeastern state. The Zoram People's Movement (ZPM) stormed into power, winning 27 seats in the 40-member assembly. For the first time ever, neither the Mizo National Front (MNF) nor the Congress will form a government. Governance has oscillated between the two parties since 1987, when Mizoram attained statehood. ZPM's victory confirms that voters in Mizoram, particularly the youth, see it as a credible alternative to existing political forces. Formed in 2017 as a coalition of six small regional parties—Mizoram People's Conference, Zoram Nationalist Party, Zoram Exodus Movement, Zoram Decentralisation Front, Zoram Reformation Front and Mizoram People's Party—it got recognition from the Election Commission in 2019. In the previous assembly poll, ZPM leaders had contested as Independent candidates and won eight seats.

Signs of the ZPM's emergence as a strong political force were evident this April when it won all 11 seats to the municipal council in Lunglei, the second largest town in Mizoram. The same month, it won all seven seats in by-elections to the Zemabawk local council, which fell under Aizawl East-1,